

Topic 4.3 - Using a standard on yourself

A real classroom situation

Two teachers in the same school are told to complete a self-evaluation against the standards.

Nadia works through the whole framework, ticks "satisfactory" in most boxes, "good" in a few, and finishes in forty minutes. Her form is complete, consistent and entirely useless. She has learned nothing, and neither will anyone reading it.

Kashif picks one indicator, about pupils contributing without prompting. He records who contributes for three lessons, finds that eleven of his thirty-eight pupils never speak, and writes that down. His form looks worse than Nadia's. It is the only one of the two that will change anything.

Explanation

Using a standard to evaluate your own practice

Self-evaluation against a standard is a cycle, not a form. The figure above gives the five stations, and the discipline is in doing them one indicator at a time.

Choose one indicator. Not a standard, not a domain: one indicator. This is the instruction trainees most often ignore, and ignoring it is what produced Nadia's forty minutes. A framework with ten standards and many indicators cannot be worked on at once, and an evaluation that covers everything examines nothing.

Choose by a simple test: which indicator, if you got better at it, would change the most for the pupils in front of you? Not the one you are weakest at in the abstract, and not the one that is easiest to evidence.

Collect evidence of current practice. Before judging. This ordering matters more than it looks, because a judgement formed first will select the evidence that confirms it. Kashif counted before he concluded.

Judge the gap honestly. Against the indicator's wording, not against your intentions. The useful question is what someone watching would have recorded, not what you were trying to do.

Plan one change. Specific, small, and yours to make without permission.

Re-collect the same evidence. The same measure, so the comparison means something. This is Unit 3's researcher role applied to yourself, and it is the station that converts self-evaluation from an opinion into a finding.

The cycle breaks in two predictable places, marked in the figure. One is choosing too many indicators, which produces Nadia's form. The other is subtler and worse: **changing the evidence rather than the practice.** A teacher who finds that eleven pupils never speak and responds by calling on them once each on the day of the observation has improved the record and changed nothing.

Building evidence against an indicator

Standards are met by evidence, and the kinds of evidence available are not equivalent. The figure above sets them against each other; the argument is below.

Pupil work. The strongest evidence for anything about learning, because it is the output the teaching was for. It shows what pupils can do. It cannot show how they came to be able to do it, which means it under-credits a teacher who inherited a weak class and over-credits one who inherited a strong one.

Observation by a colleague. Shows practice directly, including the things a teacher cannot see themselves, such as which side of the room they neglect. It is expensive, it samples one lesson, and the lesson observed is rarely typical, because knowing you are observed changes what you do.

Planning documents. Show intention and structure, and are the easiest of all to produce without the underlying competence. A beautiful scheme of work is evidence of an afternoon's writing, not of a term's teaching.

Pupil voice. Pupils asked properly are surprisingly accurate about whether they feel able to ask questions, whether marking helps them, and whether the teacher notices them. It is the most under-used evidence in most schools. It requires care: pupils asked in the teacher's presence will say what is safe.

The teacher's own record. Counts, tallies, notes kept over time. Weak as proof to somebody else and excellent for the purpose that matters here, which is finding out something you did not know about your own room.

The practical rule: **triangulate cheaply**. Two kinds of evidence that fail in different ways are worth far more than one kind collected thoroughly. Kashif's tally plus five minutes of pupil voice would establish something neither could alone.

A second rule follows from the whole topic and is worth stating plainly. **Self-evaluation and appraisal must not be the same document.** The moment a teacher's honest record of a weakness feeds a promotion decision, honest records stop appearing. Kashif's finding, that eleven pupils never speak, is the most professionally valuable sentence either teacher wrote, and in a system that used it against him he would never have written it. Isoré (2009) records this as a design problem rather than a failure of individual integrity: evaluation systems that mix developmental and accountability purposes reliably degrade the developmental one.

Topic 4.4 takes that problem up directly.

Activity: One indicator, two kinds of evidence

Work in pairs.

Each person chooses one indicator relevant to a class they teach or have observed. State it aloud, then plan two kinds of evidence from the figure that fail in different ways, and say exactly what you would collect, when, and what result would count as a gap.

Your partner's job is to attack the plan on one question only: **how could you satisfy this evidence without actually improving?** Revise the plan until the

attack fails or until you can say why the risk is acceptable.

Allow 25 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. Name the five stations of the self-evaluation cycle in order. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why evidence should be collected before the judgement is formed. (*Understand*)
3. Nadia and Kashif produced very different forms. Explain which is more professionally useful and why the better one looks worse. (*Apply*)
4. For any three kinds of evidence, state what each shows well and what it cannot show. (*Remember*)
5. Explain why self-evaluation and appraisal should not be the same document, using Kashif's finding as the example. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Self-evaluation against a standard is a five-station cycle: choose one indicator, collect evidence of current practice, judge the gap against the indicator's wording, plan one change you can make without permission, and re-collect the same evidence. It breaks in two places: taking on too many indicators at once, and changing the evidence rather than the practice.

Kinds of evidence are not equivalent. Pupil work shows outcomes but not attribution; observation shows practice but samples an atypical lesson; planning documents are the easiest to produce without competence; pupil voice is accurate and under-used but must be collected carefully; a teacher's own record is weak as proof and excellent for discovery. Triangulating two kinds that fail differently beats collecting one thoroughly.

Because an honest self-evaluation records weakness, it cannot safely be the same document as an appraisal that carries consequences. Mixing the purposes degrades the developmental one, which is a design problem rather than a failure of individual honesty.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can run the self-evaluation cycle on one indicator without expanding it to cover everything.
- ☐ I can collect evidence before forming the judgement.
- ☐ I can name what each kind of evidence shows and fails to show.
- ☐ I can design a two-kind triangulation for an indicator I care about.
- ☐ I can explain why honest self-evaluation requires separation from consequential appraisal.

Try this at your practicum school

Run one full cycle. Choose a single indicator, collect evidence across three lessons, judge the gap in writing, make one change, and re-collect the same evidence.

Three lessons is enough for the first four stations and probably not enough for the fifth to show anything, and that is a genuine finding to report rather than a failure of the exercise. Write half a page including what you would need to see a real change, and be explicit about whether you were tempted at any point to improve the record instead of the practice.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Nadia's form was complete and useless; Kashif's looked worse and was not. Evaluate the two self-evaluations, and design the system that would produce more Kashifs.

Your answer must analyse what each teacher's form achieves, identify what in a school's handling of self-evaluation produces Nadia's behaviour, and propose concrete arrangements. Address the obvious objection that a system which never records a weakness against a teacher cannot hold anyone accountable.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Analysis of the two forms (Apply)	Explains the professional value of each rather than praising honesty in general
Diagnosis of cause (Analyze)	Locates Nadia's behaviour in the system's handling, not in her character
Design proposal (Create)	Proposes concrete arrangements, including what separates development from appraisal, that a real school could adopt
Handling of the accountability objection (Evaluate)	Answers how accountability survives separation, rather than choosing development and ignoring it

Further reading

- Isoré, M. (2009). *Teacher evaluation: Current practices in OECD countries and a literature review* (OECD Education Working Papers No. 23). OECD Publishing. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED530786.pdf>
- Government of Pakistan, Ministry of Education (2009). *National Professional Standards for Teachers in Pakistan*.

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback